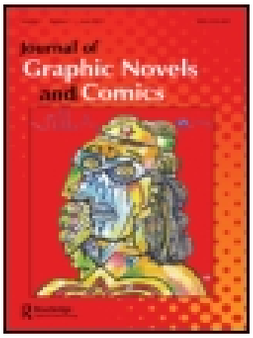

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Discordant discourses: history and journalism in the graphic novels of Joe Sacco

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ABSTRACT
Joe Sacco's graphic novels are often described as comics journalism, even though many of them evidence a distinctly historical method. This essay discusses the development of an engagement with the past in Sacco's oeuvre and asserts that *Safe Area Gorazde* is the first long-form work where he fully deploys journalism and history together. A close reading of that work demonstrates that these two approaches are not combined into a synthesis as many scholars often assume. Instead, journalism and history largely unfold as separate modes of discourse alongside one another and as such are doubly performative: they transform our awareness of the present as well as our understanding of the past. Sacco was born on Malta but his family soon moved to Australia and then to the United States, where he studied journalism in college. He became involved with alternative comics in the 1980s. While travelling during the early 1990s, he visited the West Bank and Gaza Strip, and his experience there led to the work *Palestine*, which gained him critical attention. That work and the others that followed established him as a "comics journalist."

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Joe Sacco is, without doubt, one of the most prominent modern representatives of 'comics journalism', a term often used by scholars and critics to describe his work.[1] Graphic novels such as *Palestine* (2001), *Safe Area Gorazde* (2000), *The Fixer* (2003a) and *Footnotes in Gaza* (2009) built his reputation for the 'ferociously honest' way that he explores violent conflicts around the world with little interference by idealism, sentimentalism, or oversimplification (Taveras 2007). 'Sacco uses comics to report on the experiences of the victims of conflict and war with a rare depth, sensitivity, and sense of context' (Woo 2010, 166). He has been described as 'the best known of the new graphic journalists' (Williams 2005, 2) and 'the contemporary force behind comics journalism' (Chute 2016, 197). Rosenblatt and Lunsford write, 'More than any other creator of comics reportage, Sacco's work is closer to traditional journalistic practices, and more than any other creator, Sacco self-consciously redefines journalism for the comic book medium' (Rosenblatt and Lunsford 2010, 69). Although journalism may be a dominant approach in his works, it is certainly not the only one. History is also a significant disciplinary mode, but it tends to receive markedly less attention.[2] And when these two modes of discourse are discussed together, it is often presumed that they operate together in a synthesis, that is, in cooperation with one another. This misguided

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assumption arguably arises in part from a lack of understanding about the fluctuating role of history in Sacco's development as an artist and writer. One graphic novel from the early-middle part of Sacco's career, *Safe Area Gorazde*, represents the first fully-fledged deployment of history alongside journalism, and an examination of the work demonstrates how these two modes of discourse often compete with and complicate one another.

It is undeniably fitting to describe Sacco as a journalist whose experiences are mediated through drawn illustrations. After all, he has a college degree in journalism, and he has published his work in newspapers and magazines such as *The Boston Globe*, *The Guardian*, *Time, New York Times Magazine* and *Harper's Magazine*. Yet he has a rather fraught relationship with it as a profession. In the preface to the volume *Journalism*, where several of his shorter graphic essays are collected, Sacco writes that 'the blessing of an inherently interpretative medium like comics is that it hasn't allowed me to lock myself within the confines of traditional journalism' (2012, xiv). Many scholars and critics consider Sacco to be an unconventional journalist due to his subversion of the mainstream media's reliance on objectivity. Regarding the type of journalism practised by Sacco, Williams (2005, 52) notes that 'its inherent subjectivity contrasts sharply with the newsroom's dispassionate prose'. This subjective approach to reporting shares commonalities with 'New Journalism, a style of literary reportage' that emerged in the 1960s and 1970s (Worden 2015, 8). The 'inherent subjectivity' in Sacco's work arises from his artwork since drawings are fundamentally interpretative. Indeed, Sacco himself avows that an artist must rely on imagination when deciding how to aesthetically depict an event, and 'It is this choosing that makes cartooning an inherently subjective medium' (Sacco 2012, xii). The personal perspective of his works is visually articulated as a first-person character-narrator who is 'a nebbishy figure in Coke-bottle glasses' (Heer 2003). This figure often appears farcical even when other characters are depicted in a serious and semi-realistic manner. For Vanderbeke (2010, 79), 'Sacco appears frequently as a little ridiculous; he misunderstands situations and occasionally does not get a joke that others share, and the cartoonish image stresses this aspect.' Yet this caricature is not simply a passive figure who observes and records. He is actively involved in gathering information and interviewing witnesses, and as such, he draws attention to the intrusive role sometimes played by journalists. By inserting himself as a comical figure into his graphic narratives, Sacco exposes his personal involvement with and effect on the people he interviews.

The pervasive view of Sacco as a comics journalist is not entirely unproblematic. Yes, he clearly uses illustrations and personal stories to explore conflicts from around the world. Yet the manifestation of journalism has fluctuated drastically across his career thus far. Indeed, it is worth noting that his early works as an artist and writer are almost entirely devoid of anything approximating a journalistic perspective. In the initial part of his career, when he was experimenting with different styles and was influenced by underground comic book artists such as Robert Crumb, Sacco tended to privilege one of two fundamental approaches: autobiography or history. Many of his graphic narratives thematised either his own personal experiences or historical moments. But he rarely, if ever, combined them together. In the 1980s, for instance, he drafted approximately 100 pages of a graphic narrative about the Vietnam War, but it was never published (Sacco 2014a, 153). Shorter works of his appearing from roughly 1987 to 1992 are collected in the volume *Notes from a Defeatist* (2003). During this five-year period of his early career, he wrote several short satirical sketches featuring the Industrial Revolution, the British Empire, and the Middle Ages (Sacco 2003b, 203–215). In 1990, he created 'When Good Bombs Happen to Bad

People,' a short work about three bombing campaigns and their effect on civilians: the bombing of Germany during 1940–1945, the bombing of Japan during 1944–1945, and the bombing of Libya during 1986. What's striking about the drawings in 'Good Bombs' is that they are accompanied by 81 quotations from 'military men, politicians, scientists, bureaucrats, and the U.S. popular media,' as Sacco states in a short introduction to the work (Sacco 2003b, 120). And each of these quotations includes a footnote with a citation, a technique that shares similarities with the scholarly discipline of history. In addition, this piece also contains a bibliography that lists several history books published by academic presses. In the same year as 'Good Bombs', Sacco also created a 21-page historical graphic narrative illustrating his mother's first-hand experiences as a child. Entitled 'More Women, More Children, More Quickly', it depicts the Axis air raids on Malta during the Second World War. All of the historically-based works from Sacco's early career utilise an unidentifiable third-person point of view, which is in stark contrast to the ubiquitous first-person character-narrator featured in his later graphic novels.

Journalism is not only difficult to discern in Sacco's early work; it is also absent in his most recent long-form project. In fact, history is the dominant mode in *The Great War*, a 24-foot long wordless panorama published in 2013 that visually renders the first day of the Battle of the Somme during World War I. Not only is this work an artistic depiction of a historical event, it was also inspired by one, and Sacco writes 'The Bayeux Tapestry, which tells the story of the Norman invasion of England, was my touchstone' (Sacco 2013, 1). In abundant detail, Sacco depicts men riding horses, marching, waiting, talking, eating, sleeping, fighting, fleeing, suffering and dying. When viewing the work as a whole, one is confronted with the vast complexity and variety of experiences on a single day of the battle. With the exception of General Douglas Haig, no individuals stand out, so that the work could be described, at least in part, as a people's history that privileges the plight of the common soldiers. The illustrated panorama is accompanied by a pamphlet containing a scholarly essay entitled '1 July 2016' excerpted from historian Adam Hochschild's book *To End All Wars*. The importance of historical discourse is also evident in the fact that Sacco, while creating the work, visited the Imperial War Museum in London and consulted British historian Julian Putkowski, an expert in the First World War. Furthermore, Sacco even cites at least 13 history books as additional sources of information (Sacco 2013, 2). Worden writes,

> *The Great War* is more historical than Sacco's previous work, in which he nearly always appears as a character in the narrative, and more impersonal, lacking the first-person narrative voice that often positions the reader in relation to the violence represented on the page. (Worden 2015, 6)

While Worden is clearly correct that *The Great War* marks a distinct methodological break from the comics journalism practised by Sacco in *Palestine*, *Safe Area Gorazde* and others, it also represents a return to the historical discourse that he employed early in his career.

Despite history's dominant role in Sacco's early writings and in his most recent major work, it often isn't closely examined in the long-form graphic novels which earned Sacco such critical and popular attention later in the early and middle part of his career. Part of the explanation for that lies with Sacco's first major work *Palestine*, which is what established Sacco's reputation as a comics journalist.

Although it appeared as a single book-length volume in 2001, it was originally published serially between 1993 and 1995 in nine separate issues entitled *Palestine #1, Palestine #2*, etc. (Worden 2015, 5). The work as a whole is narrated in the first person by Sacco who retells his experiences and shares the interviews that he conducted in the winter of 1991–1992 when the first intifada or uprising was 'beginning to run out of steam' (Sacco 2001, vi). The graphic narrative plainly privileges a journalist approach. Sacco acknowledges that 'With *Palestine*, my training in journalism played a big role in my motivation. When I began to read about what was actually going on with the Palestinian issue, I was furious at American journalists and the American style of journalism in which I had been trained' (Sacco 2014b, 54). He realised that mere facts were insufficient to explain the conflict, and that a new approach was needed, one that was more personal and more involved in the lives of those who were suffering. There was a noteworthy development that took place as Sacco worked on *Palestine* – he gradually adopted a more representational style of drawing. In the early issues, many if not all of the figures were depicted in an exaggerated and semi-grotesque manner reminiscent of the underground comics tradition, but Sacco soon realised that he was inadvertently feeding into cultural stereotypes, and he then shifted to a more realistic style. In describing this change, he says, 'I thought, well, if this is aspiring for some sort of journalistic truth, I have to be a bit more accurate in how I portray people and things' (Sacco 2014b, 54). This artistic development arose out of his commitment to the notion of accuracy or authenticity in journalistic discourse.

Palestine is not the only graphic novel that revolves around the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, and Sacco is also the author of *Footnotes in Gaza*, published in 2009. Despite their shared geographic focus and their shared reliance on personal interviews, the distinction between the works could not be greater. It would be fair to claim that history is largely elided in *Palestine*. By contrast, *Footnotes in Gaza* explicitly seeks to uncover the past. The inspiration for the work reportedly came from a United Nations report about two uprisings by the Palestinians in the Gaza Strip during 1956 and the resulting Israeli crackdown.[3] According to Ben Owen, Sacco seeks 'to make the Gazan experience of 1956 visible to a non-Palestinian audience, but he does not want to make it a fully assimilated part of a European or American history of the Middle East' (Owen 2015, 219). The work's purpose, then, is to explore these events while also unsettling the conventional Western historical narrative of the region. Although *Footnotes in Gaza* utilises interviews in the narrative present, they are primarily used to draw attention to the massacres then. This past is not isolated and distant from contemporary life, and Sacco points out that 'It's almost as if history bleeds. In people's minds, one bit of history bleeds into another bit of history [...] history hasn't really stopped' (Sacco 2014a, 145). Through both journalistic-style interviews and historical research, *Footnotes in Gaza* epitomises how an understanding of past can inform the present.

The historical approach pervading *Footnotes in Gaza* is first evident in its title, which evokes the bibliographic conventions for citing sources used by historians and other scholars. Footnotes are a way of providing supporting evidence without disturbing the main narrative of an academic argument. But they can also be used to marginalise information not directly relevant to that narrative, and it is in this sense that Sacco views them as a metaphor for the Palestinians. Alongside an image depicting violence in

1956, he writes: 'Well, like most footnotes, they dropped to the bottom of history's pages, where they barely hang on' (Sacco 2009, 8). For Sacco, the historical narrative of the West tends to overlook the Palestinian experience. The concern with victims that Sacco expresses in many of his other works is palatable in *Footnotes in Gaza*, too, but it is primarily a concern with the victims of history, not with those of a contemporary conflict. It is telling that Sacco, in discussions of the work, has sometimes avoided the journalistic word 'interview' to describe the way that he personally collected information from individuals. Instead, he often calls it 'eyewitness testimony', a term that suggests the kind of oral evidence made in a court of law (Sacco 2014a, 149). Indeed, the graphic novel, which interrogates the injustices of the past, uses historical documents and research to build its case. At the end of *Footnotes in Gaza*, there is a section entitled 'Archives and People Consulted', and here it can be read that 'A number of Israelis – former military men, families of deceased military men, and historians – were contacted to see if more light could be shed on the events' (Sacco 2009, 416). Sacco furthermore states that he was even assisted by a researcher and that he consulted several professional historians.

With Sacco's oeuvre, we are thus faced with a conundrum. Although there are a number of early works that are primarily historical in nature, his first long-form graphic narrative, *Palestine*, is considered a work of comics journalism. And the works later in his career are either dominated by a historical approach (*The Great War*) or history is a major disciplinary discourse alongside journalism (*Footnotes in Gaza*). But where did this shift take place? *Safe Area Gorazde* is significant because it first demonstrates a historical perspective alongside the journalistic approach that he had first fully utilised in *Palestine*. This early intersection of journalism and history in *Safe Area Gorazde* is especially worth investigating because there is arguably an underlying misconception about the way that Sacco implements them. When scholars discuss the different modes of discourse in Sacco's long-form works, they often presume that they operate in some sort of a harmonic relationship. W.J.T. Mitchell asserts, 'His unique *synthesis* of journalism, history, and comics has revolutionized the nature of the medium' (Sacco 2014b, 53; emphasis added). Worden expresses a similar view when he writes, 'Sacco's blending of his own experiences as reporter with witness testimony, historical research, and military mapping achieves a *synthesis*' (Worden 2015, 11; emphasis added). The ostensibly synthetic relationship between history and journalism needs further examination and there is evidence that Sacco employs discordant modes of discourse in *Safe Area Gorazde*.

The term 'discourse' can have a range of meanings, but it is employed here in the general sense of critical discourse analysis to describe the way that language shapes thinking and behaviour. For Michel Foucault, discourses can be viewed as 'practices that systematically form the objects of which they speak' (Foucault 1972, 49). A given discourse contains a set of assumptions that frame the way that knowledge is produced and actions are taken. By normalising one type of discourse and accepting its legitimacy, we risk marginalising alternative modes of understanding. Yet history and journalism are not merely abstract modes of discourse; they are specific types of disciplinary discourse that provide linguistic tools to professional and academic communities. By identifying and understanding disciplinary discourses, we gain the 'ability of negotiate and establish a plurality of cultural norms in disciplines' (Hyland 2004, 2).

In order to achieve something approximating epistemological openness, it is incumbent that we be attentive to different modes of discourse in order to reflect on the cultural assumptions embedded in language, whether that language is textual or visual.

Journalism plays a major role in the plot of *Safe Area Gorazde: The War in Eastern Bosnia 1992–1995* (2000), and Sacco's first-person character-narrator frequently identifies himself as a journalist. Yet this professional identity is also unsettled and complicated on multiple occasions. A fraught attitude towards it is first witnessed in the work's prologue, which begins *in medias res* in November 1995 as the Bosnian War is drawing to a close. While sitting in a café waiting for news about the anticipated announcement of a ceasefire, Sacco is approached by a man who offers to tell him everything that happened in the besieged Bosnian enclave of Gorazde. Sacco reports the man's speech in the third person in a narrative box at the top of a frame: 'And if I were a real journalist, he said, who sought the Real Truth, I would visit him and look over his manuscript about Gorazde' (2000, ii). In the next and penultimate frame of the prologue, Sacco states that he avoided the man after that evening, tacitly suggesting that he is neither a 'real journalist' nor interested in pursuing the 'Real Truth' as a capitalised singularity. This interaction in the prologue is significant because it questions the assumption that 'journalism's first obligation is to the truth', as is claimed by Kovach and Rosensteil in their book *The Elements of Journalism* (2001, 12). Sacco's resistance to the presumed objective principles of traditional journalism is a recurring motif of the graphic novel, which seeks to explore the causes and effects of the Bosnian War through multiple perspectives. This critical attitude towards traditional journalism is continued in the graphic novel's main story line, which begins immediately after the prologue. It involves an analepsis or flashback to a point several months earlier when the war was still being fought. As Sacco and a few other reporters first arrive in the besieged city and step out of their armoured vehicles in the UN convoy, local officials greet them as if they were celebrities. This red-carpet treatment causes Sacco to reflect on the fast-paced news cycle: 'Gorazde! Which was getting CNNed! NPRed! BBCed! But its proverbial 15 minutes were ticking away! Pretty soon no one was gonna remember Gorazde!' (2000, 6). With heavy irony, Sacco here critiques the mainstream media's brief attention span. By contrast, Sacco is not here for just a quick story, and he ends up staying for an extended period of time in order to gain a fuller and more thorough understanding of the city and its inhabitants.

For Sacco, the mainstream media treat news as a commercial commodity that is most valuable when it is timely and sensationalistic. As a discourse, journalism differs in this respect from the writing of history, which largely operates without time pressure. Journalism scholar Sandra Borden writes:

> In fact, time itself – particularly the present – seems to be a good in journalism. Journalists value the present in the sense of being present – wanting to be a witness, to be in the know – and in the sense of the current times – wanting to record what is happening now, to get the word out now, to make sure that today is not forgotten. If historians hope to recapture the past for present times, journalists hope to capture the present so that it may one day become a record of the past; it is in this sense that journalists write the first draft of history. (Borden 2007, 63)

Theorists of history tend to agree with this notion that journalists operate in the present while historians operate in the past. In *Essaying the Past: How to Read, Write, and Think about History*, Jim Cullen writes:

> Historical writing is decisively shaped by the way time creates a relative scarcity of information. For journalists, it is typically time itself that's scarce – there are lots of potential people with whom to talk, but a looming deadline that sets priorities about who's going to get the most attention, which may involve persuading someone with information to admit they have it. Historians, by contrast, are relatively insulated from deadlines, which when present are measured in years rather than hours. (Cullen 2009, 21–22)

For these two authors, journalism and history share an approach to events but differ primarily in their relationship to time. While journalists are concerned with conveying information about current events to a waiting audience, historians require more time to reflect about and analyse past events. It could be claimed that the two discourses operate along a common continuum but with differing attitudes to temporality.

If time is a primary feature that differentiates journalism from history, then there is cause to rethink the notion that Sacco is primarily a practitioner of journalism. Indeed, the pace at which he works arguably has more in common with a historian than a journalist, and not only because he was not working under a publication deadline for a periodical. The comics medium is extremely uneconomical when it comes to the amount of time needed for the process of creation, and Jared Gardner asserts that there is a 'vast amount of time required to produce an ambitious comic', a situation that leads to temporal dislocations between producer and consumer, artist and reader (Gardner 2015, 21). Sacco's research first started when he visited the city of Gorazde in late 1995. And because Sacco dates all his work, we know that the drawings in *Safe Area Gorazde* span almost four years, from June 1996 until March of 2000 (Sacco 2000, 1, 227). This length of time is not inconsistent with what it might take to write a scholarly work of history. In addition, the publication of Sacco's *Safe Area Gorazde* took place almost five years after the Bosnian War ended in late 1995, and thus it cannot be described as reporting on anything resembling current events. Because the Bosnian city of Gorazde was completely absent from major newspapers and magazines in the year that Sacco's graphic novel was published, Gardner (2015, 27) argues convincingly that 'Sacco's "news" is always caught in the past'. The various players in the Bosnian War were either gone or slowly fading away by 2000. Bill Clinton, who played a central role in the international community's reaction to the war, was in the final months of his second term as President of the United States. In October of 2000, Serbian strongman Slobodan Milosevic finally lost power, having conceded defeat in the election for President of the Federal Republic of Yugoslavia.[4] Although Yugoslavia continued to exist for a few more years as a rump state comprising Serbia and Montenegro, Bosnia had largely stabilised and was receiving little attention in international periodicals by the time that *Safe Area Gorazde* was published.

> Journalists, to the extent that they are practicing journalists, have a practical goal in mind. They acquire and communicate knowledge for the sake of providing people with what they need to know to make good decisions about what should be done or what should be avoided concerning the issues currently facing them. (Bovee 1999, 20)

If journalism is a discourse with a practical purpose, as is suggested here, then Sacco's affiliation with it should be rethought since *Safe Area Gorazde* was not intended to influence any policies of the immediate present when it was published.

A historical discourse is clearly articulated in the narrative structure of *Safe Area Gorazde*. The graphic novel is divided into chapter-length episodes, each with a descriptive title. Yet there are two distinct types of chapters. The first type involves pages with white backgrounds, margins, and gutters (or occasionally illustrations that extend to the edge of the page). These chapters, which are dominated by a combination of autobiography and journalism, depict Joe Sacco's first-hand experiences in the city of Gorazde. On one page from this type of chapter, Sacco depicts himself waking up after a night of heavy drinking (Figure 1). The next frame portrays him competing with foreign journalists for access to Edin, a well-connected local Bosnian teacher who acts as a guide and translator and who later becomes Sacco's friend. The last scene on this page evokes critical reflection about the way that reporters craft their stories. 'I'm next,' Sacco says impatiently as he waits for a cameraman to finish filming what appears to be a choreographed scene with a well-dressed family (Sacco 2000, 12). The twofold implication here seems to be that access is crucial for gathering information, and that the choice of subject can be capricious. On the edges of this last frame, less photogenic locals stand around awkwardly watching the interview. The visual language here is relatively unconventional, and the three basic frames on the page overlap and contrast with regard to angle. The first frame on this page is completely marked-off by a lined border, but it does not have all right angles; the second frame only has some border lines on the bottom and left corner; the final frame has no borders at all.

The second type of chapter, by contrast, always presents clear borders with right angles. More importantly, these chapters are visually marked by black margins and gutters, which signal the onset of historical information about the complicated ethnic conflict of the Bosnian War. *Safe Area Gorazde* features eight black-bordered chapters, altogether totalling 100 pages in a graphic novel that is 227 pages long. Thus, almost half of the work features a historical perspective on the Bosnian War and the events in Gorazde. These black-bordered chapters typically begin with an individual providing testimony in quotation marks. But these chapters all adopt a unique discursive feature: the witness's statement is typically followed by a sketch of the region's history presented in the third-person. In an interview, Sacco even characterised these chapters as 'the historical track that took the reader chronologically through the major incidents of the war' (Sacco 2011b, 237). The first historical chapter, for example, is entitled 'Brotherhood and Unity', and it opens with a drawing of Edin, who stares out of the page at us and presumably at Sacco as his interlocutor. 'I spent a very nice childhood. I didn't make any distinction between Serb, Croat, and Muslim children' (Sacco 2000, 18). But after one page of Edin's personal testimony, a third-person voice takes over and retells Yugoslavian history (Figure 2). The narrative reads, 'Modern Yugoslavia was fashioned out of the wreckage of the Kingdom of Yugoslavia after World War II by the Communist resistance leader Josip Broz, better known as Tito' (2000, 19). The next several frames on this page show historical maps of Yugoslavia before its break-up in the 1990s. For Edward Holland, these cartographic forms are primarily informative:

Figure 1. Joe Sacco, *Safe Area Gorazde* (Seattle: Fantagraphics, 2000), 12.

'Maps underlie the process of communicating the history of the war in Bosnia to the readership of Sacco's graphic narratives' (Holland 2015, 90). By incorporating traditional cartography, Sacco presents a distant and objective perspective of moments in the history of the Balkans.

Figure 2. Joe Sacco, *Safe Area Gorazde* (Seattle: Fantagraphics, 2000), 19.

The primary feature differentiating the historical chapters with the black borders is an absence, namely the absence of Sacco as a character-narrator. Nowhere is there an image of him. And nowhere do we read any first-person pronouns or other self-

referential statements that are otherwise so prevalent throughout *Safe Area Gorazde*. Indeed, Sacco's conspicuously subjective role in the white-bordered chapters gives way in the black-bordered chapters to something that approximates an objective perspective. 'The frequent deployment of irony' that otherwise characterizes Sacco's journalist identity is also completely missing in the black-bordered chapters (Maher 2015, 233). The need for a detached, serious, third-person perspective arose from Sacco's conviction that the Bosnian conflict itself had deep roots in the past, and that it would be inappropriate to present this past in an overtly subjective manner. In an interview, he acknowledges the complicated national alliances in the Balkans during the First and Second World Wars. 'I'm not an academic who can trace all the alliances down to the final detail but to me what was happening in the 1990s, when you cleared all the smoke, people were being slaughtered on a great scale because of their nationality' (Sacco 2011b, 250). With the black-bordered chapters, Sacco then seeks to 'clear the smoke' and to traces the many causes of the Bosnian War.

The eight black-bordered chapters narrate the region's history, starting with ethnic unrest in the Second World War and ending with the Dayton Peace Talks of November 1995. Indeed, they contain a plethora of year markers that are arranged in strict chronological order and, taken as a whole, they foreground the linearity of the historical narrative.[5] The linear representation of time here is significantly different from *Footnotes in Gaza*, which was published nine years later. Ben Owen persuasively contends that this later work is deeply historical, but that it embodies incommensurate temporal experiences. He writes, '*Footnotes* presents several different modes of narrating history, focusing on the conflict between two different modes, the progressive and the cyclical' (Owen 2015, 203). For Owen, it is significant that these conflicting notions of history are never resolved. '*Footnotes in Gaza* insists that the history of the event can only appear as a dialectic – the emotional truth and the factual truth cannot coexist as a single, seamless narrative, but must instead serve as discontinuous indexes of one another' (Owen 2015, 218).

Unlike in *Footnotes in Gaza*, the black-bordered chapters of *Safe Area Gorazde* comprise a single, continuous historical narrative without any significant ruptures. While these historical chapters construct a linear story about the past, they are not well integrated into the narrative present as depicted by Sacco in the chapters with white borders and gutters. The two types of chapters in *Safe Area Gorazde*, the journalistic white-bordered chapters and the historical black-bordered chapters, unfold alongside each other but there is often little or no real connection between them. They therefore can be described as two discordant modes of discourse that are never resolved. The white-bordered chapters feature Sacco's first-person voice, his irony, his image, and a visual language that is more fluid and experimental. By contrast, the black-bordered chapters embody a third-person historical narrative with a linear chronology and a visual language that relies on clear borders and right angles.

The source of the information in the historical chapters becomes clear in the bibliography, where Sacco identifies the published books that he consulted while researching the complex socio-political circumstances that led to the Bosnian War and its human suffering. Indeed, the significant role of history in the work is attested to by the bibliographical apparatus where there are nine different books on the subject. It is here, after the illustrations end, that there is tangible evidence for the role of history

in Sacco's *Safe Area Gorazde*. Many of the books listed here are by scholarly historians, substantiating the claim that the graphic novel seeks to participate in a conversation about the historical understanding of the Bosnian War.

The historical discourse *in Safe Area Gorazde* is embedded within an autobiographical story about Sacco's experiences in Gorazde. The story begins in earnest when the mainstream journalists depart in search for more dramatic news elsewhere on the planet, leaving Sacco as one of the few Western civilians there. He quickly abandons the city's tourist-oriented hotel and moves in with Edin, and they soon become friends. Indeed, this close relationship enables Sacco to have direct contact with numerous Gorazde inhabitants.[6] During his stay there, Sacco interviews eyewitnesses about the Bosnian War, but he also experiences everyday life with Edin and his friends. They meet for improvised meals in bleak, bombed-out apartments, go to makeshift discos, and watch the few outdated movies that happen to be available on videocassette. Sacco also befriends Riki, a Bosnian man who often bursts out in uninhibited and spontaneous renditions of American rock songs. Visually, Riki is depicted as inconspicuous-looking, but when he sings, he appears enveloped in a halo of light that visually conveys the charm of his unbounded enthusiasm, if not musical talent (Sacco 2000, 24). This drawing expresses the powerful impression that he makes on Sacco's first-person character-narrator, whose friendships with Edin, Riki, and others lend the graphic novel a personal dimension. These relationships make it possible for Sacco to include the personal perspectives of Bosnian Muslims in his examination of the war. In several scenes throughout the graphic novel, Sacco listens passively whenever Riki croons a song, but near the end, he finally joins Riki, and together they sing 'Proud Mary' by Creedence Clearwater Revival (Sacco 2000, 219). It is not only that the words of Sacco and Riki are in synch; Sacco's voice has merged, albeit briefly, with a Bosnian one. Here, in the white-bordered chapters, Sacco's character-narrator demonstrates a willingness to blur the boundary between subject and object, observer and observed. The centrality of these personal relationships for the narrative is illustrated in the work's epilogue, when Sacco returns to Gorazde in January 1996, just after the ceasefire took effect and the siege of the city was lifted. Edin is already gone and Riki is about to leave. Sacco writes, 'I stayed just two days [. . .] I was lost. I didn't know this place' (Sacco 2000, 223). Without the presence of his friends, Sacco's character-narrator departs, too, since he no longer has any orientation or personal connection to the city.

While the white-bordered chapters in *Safe Area Gorazde* feature Sacco as a ubiquitous character-narrator, they contain only passing references to violence. The graphic depictions of violence, by contrast, are limited to the black-bordered chapters. There are likely two basic reasons for this divergence. First, these black-bordered chapters enable Sacco to explore the past prior to his arrival in Bosnia in the fall of 1995, just as the Bosnian War was ending. Journalistic discourse would have been inadequate to report what happened earlier, and thus Sacco resorts to a methodology reminiscent of historical writing. Second, these black-bordered chapters provide Sacco the writer and artist with the emotional distance to deal with the most difficult issues of the conflict. After all, these chapters are retold in the third person without the irony or doubt about the 'Real Truth' that is so conspicuous in the white-bordered chapters, as is discussed above. In one black-bordered chapter, we see the decomposing bodies of murdered Bosnians being unearthed and re-interned according to Muslim custom. Edin states, 'It was terrible smelling. Worms.

Death. We recognized them mainly from their clothes, but also from their hair … and the features of their faces. There was still skin' (Sacco 2000, 92). As horrifying as these visual images are, they depict people who are already dead. More disturbing are the drawings which directly portray the act of murder. An eyewitness named Rasim offers testimony about the way that the Serb Chetniks slaughtered hundreds of Bosnian civilians on the bridge over the river Drina in the town of Visegrad. In the black-bordered frame where he says, 'Sometimes they shot them, but they preferred to cut their throats', we see a graphic depiction of one man using a knife to slash the throat of a victim (Sacco 2000, 110). Although Sacco's artwork is entirely black and white, it still effectively conveys the blood-soaked inhumanity of this genocidal act. The history of the war's brutality culminates in the eighth and final black-bordered chapter entitled 'Death and Deliverance', where one especially unsettling image depicts the massacre of Srebrenica (Figure 3; Sacco 2000, 203). This frame articulates the graphic novel's participation in historical discourse. The massacre had been widely reported by the time that Sacco included it in *Safe Area Gorazde*, and he is thus not acting here as a journalist. What he does, however, is reimagine the event from a neutral third-person perspective. An oversized frame shows a freshly dug trench with numerous corpses. Alongside the trench, a number of blindfolded men are in the process of being shot by Serb Chetniks. The text accompanying the drawing describes the event in a matter-of-fact tone. Evoking a direct comparison with the Holocaust, one of the worst atrocities of human history, the third-person narration states, 'It was the largest mass killing in Europe in 50 years' (Sacco 2000, 203). Sacco's depiction of the massacre is also unique because he embeds it within the story of two Bosnian Muslims named Nermin and Haso. They describe how they saw some civilians murdered by Serb Chetniks in the forest near Srebrenica in 1995. But since they didn't actually observe the mass shooting in Srebrenica themselves, they cannot speak about it directly. Yet their witness testimony creates a historical framework that allows the reader to connect individual stories with the massacre in Srebrenica.

The role of history in *Safe Area Gorazde* has not been overlooked by scholars, and Lan Dong, for instance, concludes that 'Sacco blends these images and representations of public history with his interviewees' personal stories' (Dong 2015, 49). Yet there is reason to doubt that the work constitutes a 'hybrid genre that combines life writing and journalism in a graphic narrative', as Dong argues (2015, 39) argues. The graphic novel certainly includes stories of local Bosnians in the present as well as a history of Bosnia in the past, but the discursive modes of journalism and history arguably have an uneasy relationship in the work. Indeed, the way that they contradict and complement each other suggests a discordant dialectical relationship. In a dialectic, the moment of synthesis typically overcomes the tension between thesis and antithesis, but the two approaches fail to come together in any meaningful combination in *Safe Area Gorazde*. Daniel Worden writes,

> To read Sacco's work is to enter into the messy complexity of history and everyday life, to feel oneself given up to historical necessity yet emboldened by the collective struggles that aspire to right wrongs and to resist military occupations, legal disenfranchisement, and economic inequality. (Worden 2015, 3)

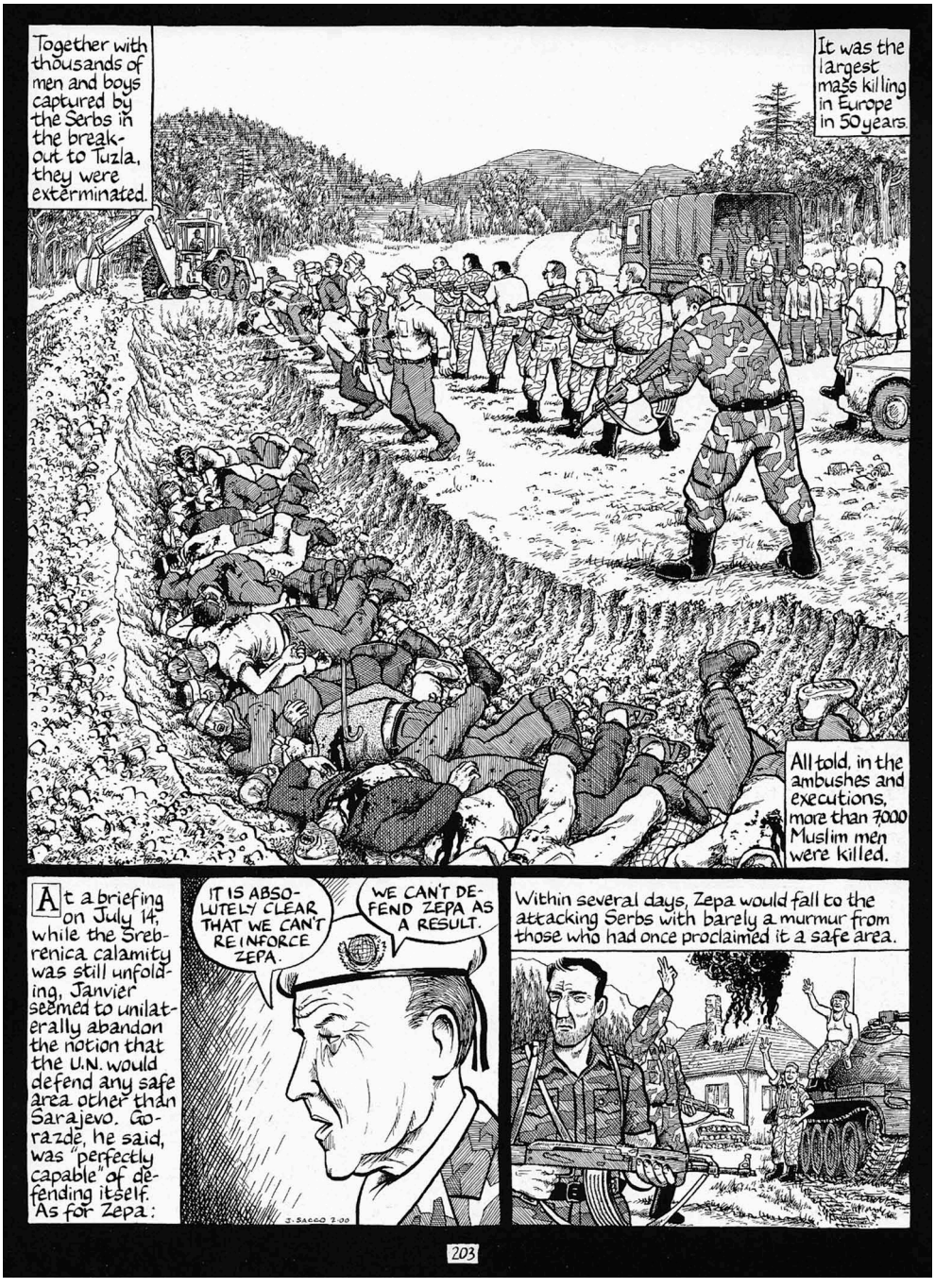

Figure 3. Joe Sacco, *Safe Area Gorazde* (Seattle: Fantagraphics, 2000), 203.

By exploring the messy complexity of the Bosnian War in *Safe Area Gorazde*, Sacco contributes just as much to an understanding of the past as an awareness of the present, creating what is effectively an early draft of history alongside a journalistic report.

Along with its comic art sibling, the graphic novel is frequently characterised as a hybrid of text and image, and Robert C. Harvey prominently writes that 'Comics are a blend of word and picture – not a simple coupling of the verbal and the visual, but a blend, a true mixture' (Harvey 1994, 9). Because text and image primarily operate in tandem with one another, their association could be termed a 'formal synthesis'. Here, a new medium arises from the fusion of two different cultural forms, literature (in its broadest sense of letters) and visual art. The widespread acknowledgement of this formal synthesis, however, casts its shadow over other types of interactions, for example over the relationships between different modes of discourse. Just because there is widespread agreement about the formal synthesis in graphic narratives, it does not follow that there is also a synthesis between modes of discourse. A close reading of *Safe Area Gorazde* reveals the way that journalism and history coexist side-by-side in an uneasy relationship. A nuanced understanding of the discourses at play in literary and visual language matters. W.J.T. Mitchell argues that we must 'approach language as a medium rather than a system, a heterogeneous field of discursive modes requiring pragmatic, dialectical description rather than a univocally coded scheme open to scientific explanation' (Mitchell 2009, 119). If discourse, as a disciplinary mode, shapes knowledge, then the question should be asked: how does our view of Sacco's graphic novels change once we recognise the different types of discourse operating in them? When scholars and critics presume that Sacco's works use a journalistic approach, they privilege the social-political engagement that his works have with the present. While that interpretation has validity, this essay argues that Sacco's graphic novel about the Bosnian War also problematises the past and discloses the complex web of forces at play in history. The chronological history of the region presented in the black-bordered chapters of *Safe Area Gorazde* seeks to inscribe the past with a linear narrative despite that past's ultimate incommensurability with the present.

But Sacco's *Safe Area Gorazde* does not only inscribe or write history. It also plays an active role in re-inscribing memories of the past and, by extension, in shaping history itself. One telling illustration of this practice emerges from a comparison with a work in a completely different cultural form. Claude Lanzmann's 1985 *Shoah* is a documentary film that explores the Holocaust through oral interviews with survivors, witnesses, and perpetrators. Lanzmann, like Sacco, was considered a journalist in his early career when he often published essays in French newspapers such as *Le Monde*. Despite Lanzmann's professional background and despite the prominence of interviews in *Shoah*, however, the film is rarely considered to be a work of journalism. Instead, many scholars view it as an 'oral history' and a record of the past (Robbins 1987 249). Although the film contains a historical narrative, it evinces several discordant approaches. Dominick LaCapra describes *Shoah* as a 'disturbingly mixed generic performance'. He elaborates, 'It is a film of endless lamentation or grieving that is tensely suspended between acting out of a traumatic past and attempting to work through it' (LaCapra 1998, 98). In a similar way, *Safe Area Gorazde* is also suspended between two different approaches; it stages a linear, third-person narrative of the Bosnian War while simultaneously exploring the present from an intensely idiosyncratic first-person perspective. Sacco is aware that his attempt to accurately portray the past has consequences.

> In the end you realize you are setting the tone for what people are going to remember about his event [...] I think, oh, is this the last image of this particular event that people

> are going to know? You realize this: there is a real, dangerous, powerful thing about representing something, because that because kind of the final word in a way. (Sacco 2014b, 61)

While Sacco has surely not written the final word, he has made an important contribution with *Safe Area Gorazde* to the evolving historical narrative of the Bosnian War. Even though Sacco's works should continue to be known as comics journalism, it also seems fitting to describe them as 'historio-graphic novels'. This term is not new, and Tony Venezia states that 'The historio-graphic text can be said to be processed *by* and to participate *in* the processing of history' (Venezia 2010, 193; italics in original). By evading any synthesis of discourse, Sacco's works are doubly performative: they transform our awareness of the present as well as our understanding of the past.

Notes

1. Even if a search is limited to the mere titles of scholarly essays and books, the term 'comics journalism' appears at least 11 times in conjunction with Joe Sacco's name. See Alla Gadassik and Sarah Henstra (2012), Isabel Macdonald (2015), Brigid Maher (2012; 2015), Juscelino Neco (2013), Sarah Owj (2017), Adam Rosenblatt and Andrea A. Lunsford (2010; 2011), Tristram Walker (2010), Kristian Williams (2005), Benjamin Woo (2010), as well as the title of the edited volume by Daniel Worden (2015).
2. The word 'history' only appears twice in titles of scholarly works about Sacco. See Hillary Chute's (2016) book chapter 'History and the Visible in Joe Sacco' and Ben Owen's (2015) essay.
3. In a book by Noam Chomsky, Sacco had read a reference to a document by the United Nations about the massacres of Khan Younis and Rafah. Sacco said he then 'just went down to the U.N. archives and found that document, and then started looking around to see what else I could find' (Sacco 2011a).
4. For a more detailed description of Milosevic's political downfall, see Steven Woehrel (2007, 236ff).
5. Overt references to years in the black-bordered chapters of *Safe Area Gorazde* (with page numbers) are: 1941 (21), 1980 (36), 1991 (37), April 1992 (39), April 1992 (41), early May 1992 (68), late May 1992 (78), June 1992 (110), end of 1992 (119), end of 1992 (134), March 1993 (143), April 1993 (148), February 1994 (162), February 1994 (164), April 1994 (165), April 1994 (167), April 1994 (179), April 1994 (184), May 1995 (197), June 1995 (197), July 1995 (198), July 1995 (203), late July 1995 (204), August 1995 (206), September–October 1995 (208), and November 1995 (212).
6. In a section at the end of the graphic novel entitled 'Special Thank Yous' [sic.], Sacco writes 'Edin and his family welcomed me in to their home like a brother and a son [. . .] If it wasn't for him, this book would not exist' (229).

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